



r/Careers • 2mo ago  
Efficient\_Weight\_868



# Vent/Warning: Karat interviews are an absolute joke for Lead/Staff roles. Never again.

I recently went through two separate Karat interview loops for two different companies, both for **Tech Lead / Senior Engineering** roles. It was, without a doubt, the most frustrating, counter-productive interview experience of my career.

If you are a senior engineer or lead who actually cares about architecture, extensibility, and deep technical conversations, consider this a warning. Karat is not looking for a Lead. They are looking for a "fast finger" typist.

Here is how both of these absolute disasters went down:

Interview 1: The 60-Minute Split (30m System Design / 30m DSA) [1]

- **System Design (30 mins):** I was asked to design an EV charging station app to find the nearest station and process payments. The interviewer spent precious time explaining basic whiteboard box-and-arrow tools, leaving almost zero time for actual design. I laid out a standard architecture: API Gateway, Load Balancer, and dedicated microservices (Payment, Location/Proximity, User Mgmt).
- **The Problem:** There was zero healthy conversation. When I tried to explain service responsibilities, the interviewer just rushed me into a checklist of generic component questions. I pointed out single points of failure with the load balancer and discussed using idempotency keys for the payment service. *Silence.* None of it registered. No follow-ups. No interest in actual engineering trade-offs.
- **DSA (30 mins):** The interviewer explicitly said they didn't want an optimized solution—just code that works. I started brainstorming a DFS approach. They cut me off and told me to just write a simple function using Maps. There was no room to break down the problem into clean, maintainable Objects.
- **The Java Tax:** Because I used Java, just typing out the verbose boilerplate and data structure declarations ate up half the remaining time crunch. It became glaringly obvious they didn't care about extensibility or maintainability. They just wanted someone to code a hacky script as fast as possible.

Interview 2: The 50-Minute "Curveball" Debugging & Feature Loop

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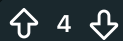
- **The Problem:** Again, zero regard for time/space complexity or optimization. Just "throw a HashMap at it and type faster." Every time I completed a function, the next requirement was a complete curveball that invalidated the data structures I had just set up.
- If you choose a strongly-typed, declarative language like Java in this format, you are heavily penalized by the clock. It is physically impossible to read, adapt to multiple curveballs, and type clean Java code in that timeframe.

### My Takeaway: The Death of Engineering Signals

At no point did either of these interviews feel like an evaluation for a Technical Lead. They do not test leadership, system stability, edge-case mitigation, or code quality. They test sprint-coding speed.

It begs the question: If a company chooses to outsource the interviewing of the very leaders who will shape their architecture, culture, and team growth... why not just outsource the whole damn project?.

I have officially decided I will never waste my energy on a Karat interview again. If a recruiter tells me their process involves Karat, I am walking away. Stay warned.



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karat interviews are leetcode speedruns, zero real leadership signal at all

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**Instrumedley2018** · 2d ago

well I currently see a bunch of roles on Linkedin for "Engineer Interviewer" position and decided to apply out of curiosity, although I find it very odd to be hiring SE to be spending their full day just interviewing people like HR and not actually building software.

Then I decided to dig the company because it sounded super sketchy and dumb and came across this thread. So it all makes sense now.